University of Essex

UK Data Archive's six-decade journey of enabling data sharing and reuse

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Economic and Social Research Council

UK • DATA ARCHIVE

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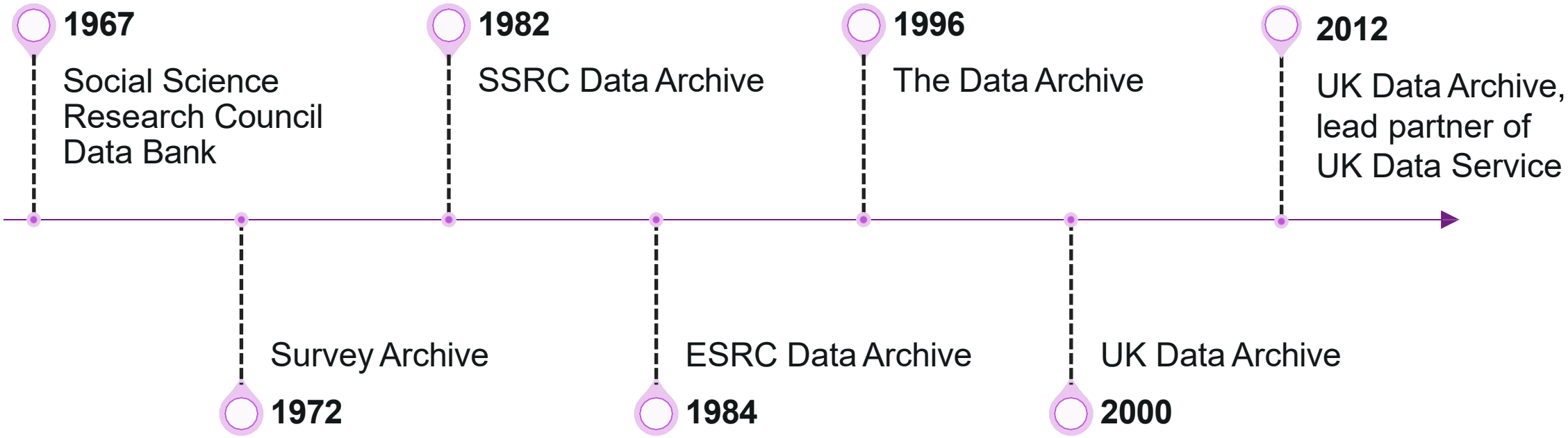
UK Data Archive evolution

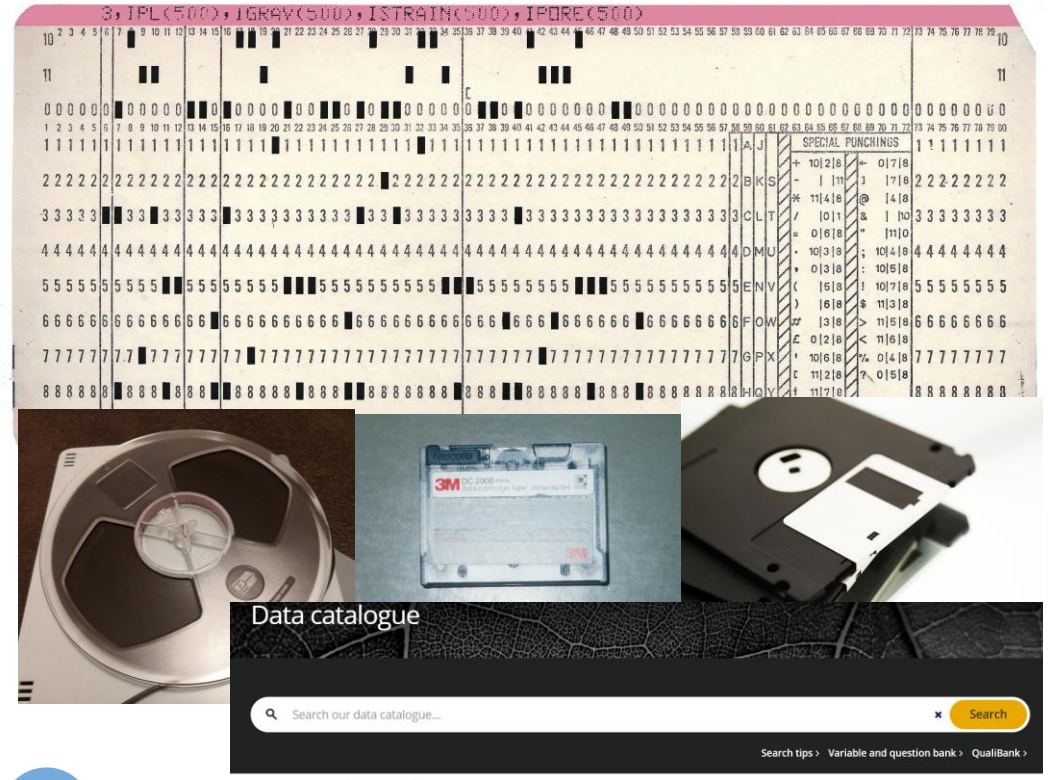


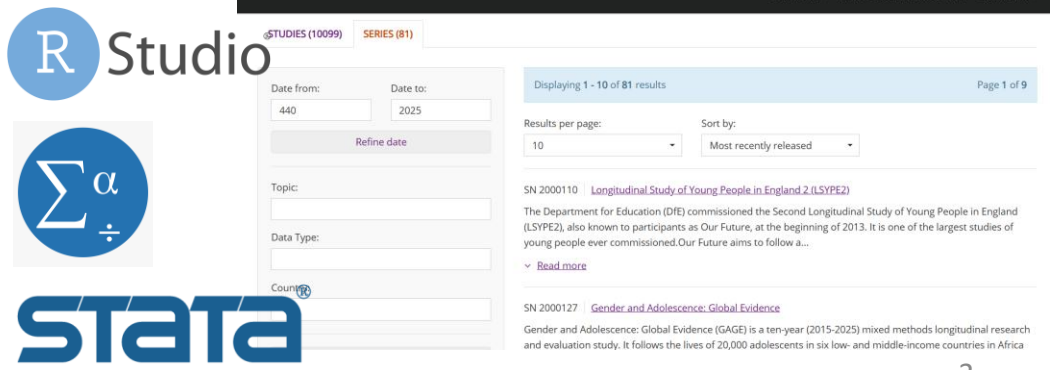
Population-representative surveys and longitudinal cohorts, qualitative/mixed methods and historical collections.

Negotiate, curate, preserve, and provide tiered access to data & train, advise, and guide.

From punch cards and paper to instant research

- Punch cards and magnetic tapes to research ready statistical formats
- Printed catalogue (1970s)
- First online data catalogue (1994)
- Open and Safeguarded direct data download (2000)
- New tier: Controlled access (SecureLab) - Trusted Research Environment (2011)
- Remote-from-home TRE (2021)





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(a) Access

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1.1. Definitions

'Agreement' this document including all of its terms and conditions.

'Registered User' a user who has registered with the UK Data Service and therefore agreed online to the terms and conditions of the Service

c. late 1960s

Non-exclusive paper licence and case-by-case approvals.

Data posted; few eligible users.

Long lead times; minimal auditability.

Present

Non-exclusive, identity-verified e-licence.

Reuse negotiated based on participant communication, data type and content.

Remote access (most instant and fully auditable).

Three tier licence and access framework

Open

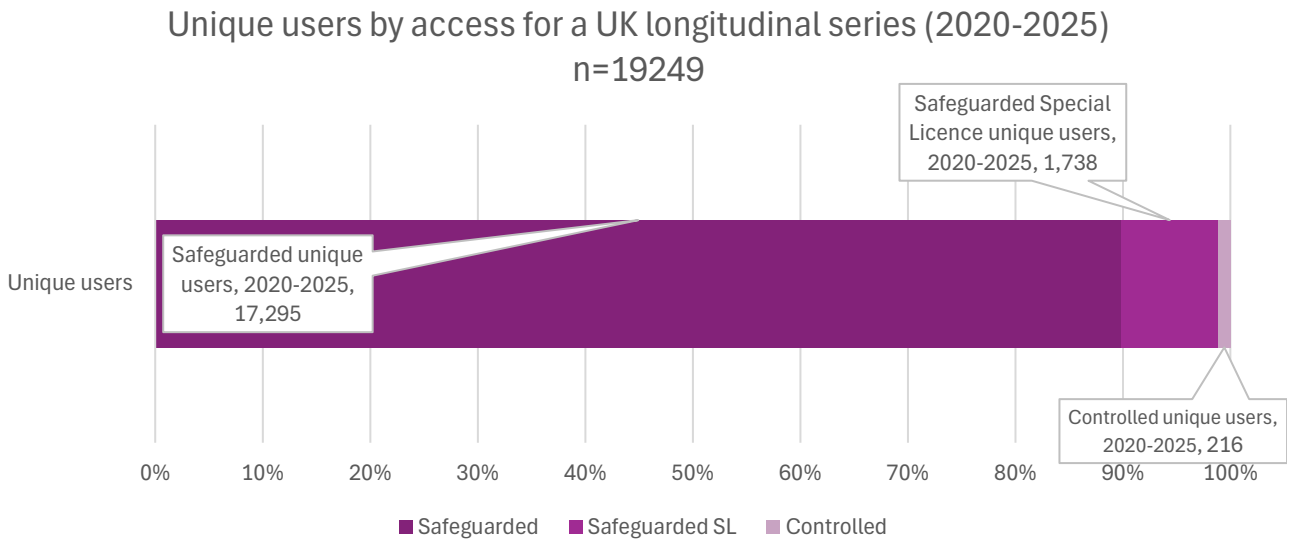
No real disclosure risk – anonymous data or consent to share data as collected is in place. Under open licences for reuse such as Creative Commons; almost no restrictions for reuse.

Safeguarded

Risk of identification is considered sufficiently remote – effectively anonymised data (ICO). Subject to the End User Licence Agreement; special conditions or agreements may apply (controlled on usage type, user type, location).

Controlled

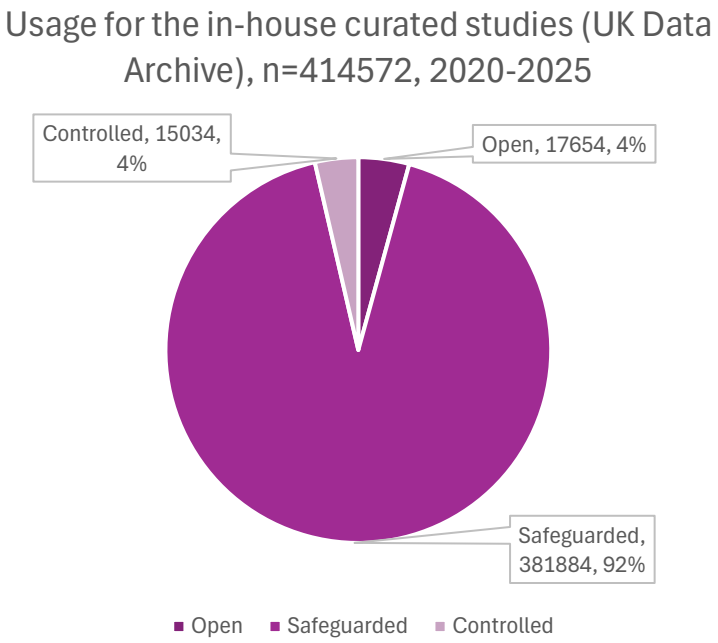
Real disclosure risk – TRE/SDE function – de-identified data, and/or highly sensitive commercially or otherwise. Subject to the End User Licence Agreement and the Secure Access User Agreement; special conditions or agreements may apply.



Proportionate access:

- Legal + ethical + technical assessment for the lowest appropriate tier.
- Coexisting versions and access: Open, Safeguarded (including additional agreements), Controlled (TRE)
- Granular reuse controls:
  - user type
  - location
  - use (teaching/non-commercial/ commercial)

Proportionate access: evidence and next steps



More semi-automated checks and processes (e.g. additional PII cues, risk prompts, metadata extraction).

Smarter secure settings (just-enough access, synthetic data for discoverability and feasibility and further dynamic controls).

Training, guidance and support. Human oversight remains critical: ethics, context and accountability.

Thank you ever so much and please don't hesitate to contact us at collections@ukdataservice.ac.uk